MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 4 — Unit 2: Indian English Drama

INDIAN WRITING IN ENGLISH • M21EG04DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Indian English drama is best understood through the interaction of multilingual traditions, performance choices, social conflict, and the institutions that bring a play to an audience.

Start with a picture

Read a confrontation silently, then imagine it performed with a long pause and an audience watching the accused person. The meaning changes because theatre organises attention through bodies and time.

1. What counts as Indian English drama?

Some plays are written originally in English, while others reach this course through translation. Dattani, Tendulkar, and Karnad cannot simply be placed in an identical publication history. Their work belongs to a multilingual field.

A translated play has a source-language context as well as an English reading and performance life. Neither dimension should be erased.

2. Traditions and modern conditions

Classical aesthetics, regional forms, colonial institutions, urban theatre, amateur groups, and public political performance contribute different resources. A playwright may combine them without producing a simple mixture of two fixed cultures.

Who funds, stages, translates, and attends the work affects its circulation. An English-language audience is not the whole Indian public.

3. Dattani: gender and family

Dance Like a Man links the control of an artistic career with masculine respectability and household power. Temporal shifts reveal that family history is remembered competitively. Connect this concern with acting, role arrangement, and transitions rather than treating the play as an essay with characters attached.

4. Tendulkar: the machinery of judgement

Silence! The Court Is in Session makes a mock legal structure expose real coercion. Changes in tone, unequal questioning, and Benare’s speech position spectators against the easy acceptance of the group’s authority.

The play’s social force depends partly on the experience of watching a performance turn into punishment.

5. Karnad: myth as an argument

The Fire and the Rain reworks inherited narrative to test knowledge, caste, ritual, desire, and compassion. Myth is not a retreat from modern questions. Its rearrangement can make contemporary assumptions available for scrutiny.

The embedded performance creates relationships between actors, spectators within the play, and the actual audience. Analyse these levels separately.

6. A method for a theatre answer

Choose one scene and identify space, bodies, speech, silence, timing, and audience knowledge. Explain how these produce a judgement or disturb one. Then connect that effect with a social issue.

Quick check

1. Were all prescribed plays first written in English? **No.**
2. Is myth necessarily an escape from present concerns? **No.**
3. Does plot summary explain a pause or an on-stage audience? **Not by itself.**

Build an exam answer

1. Distinguish theme from theatrical method.
2. Use Dattani’s shifts in time.
3. Analyse Tendulkar’s mock court.
4. Discuss Karnad’s embedded performance.
5. Connect audience and translation with social effect.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not describe a play only as a story or imply that its English edition exhausts its linguistic and performance history.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Explain how performance makes social criticism effective in the prescribed dramas.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

The social concerns of the prescribed dramas cannot be separated from their theatrical construction. A plot summary may identify patriarchy or caste, but it does not explain how a spectator is made to recognise the pressure. Performance distributes visibility, voice, and authority in ways a general thematic statement cannot reproduce.

Dattani’s movement between times makes the persistence of family power perceptible. Competing memories are embodied rather than reported from a secure position outside the conflict. Tendulkar uses a different arrangement: the conventions of a mock court acquire force as participants turn a game against Benare. The audience must evaluate the authority being manufactured before it.

Karnad’s mythic and embedded performances add another level. Those watching a play within the play can encounter a disturbing resemblance to their own conduct. The relation between ritual prestige and compassion becomes dramatic rather than merely conceptual.

An effective answer should connect such methods with the multilingual and institutional field in which the works circulate. Translation, staging, and audience shape the social reach of a critique. The result is not a choice between form and politics: theatrical form is one of the ways political relations become available for judgement.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt’s assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. Critically examine Mahesh Dattani’s play Dance Like a Man from a traditional point of view.
2. How does Vijay Tendulkar’s play, Silence! The Court is in Session, portray the deficiencies of the Indian judiciary? Explain.
3. How does Girish Karnad present the true face of Indian society through his play, The Fire and the Rain?